Team Rules for OpenAI Codex with AGENTS.md



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Overview



What if your newest teammate forgot everything, every task?

That's how Codex starts work, unless you give it a note.

WHAT'S IN IT FOR YOU

Codex pull requests that follow your team's rules the first time.

ONE WEEK IN A TEAM

- **Mon** — New hire
- **Tue-Wed** — Ping-pong
- **Thu** — The note
- **Fri** — The proof

Monday: Sam joins the team



Mina
Tech lead

Sam
New developer

TEAM NOTES FOR SAM

- ☐ **Bad input? Raise AppError with a code.**
- ☐ **Test with the team command.**
- ☐ **Add a line to CHANGELOG.md.**

20 minutes.
Sam remembers all week.

Tuesday: Codex joins.
Nobody onboards it.

Tuesday: the review ping-pong

🤖 **Codex:** PR #57: add apply_coupon()

👩‍💼 **Maliha:** Use AppError, not ValueError.

🤖 **Codex:** Fixed.

👩‍💼 **Maliha:** Where are the tests?

🤖 **Codex:** Added.

👩‍💼 **Maliha:** And the CHANGELOG.md line?

3 rounds

Wednesday: new tasks, same three comments

🤖 Gift cards	🤖 Refunds	🤖 Shipping	🤖 Wishlists
Use AppError	Use AppError	Use AppError	Use AppError
Add tests	Add tests	Add tests	Add tests
Update CHANGELOG	Update CHANGELOG	Update CHANGELOG	Update CHANGELOG

Sam learned once. For Codex, every task is day one.

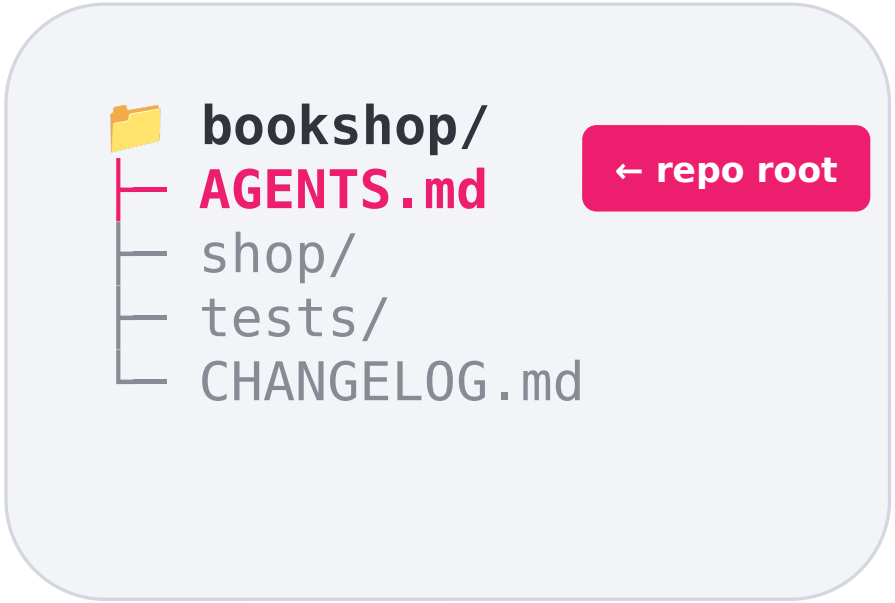
“Codex isn't bad at our rules.
It has never read them.”

Maliha, Thursday morning

AGENTS.md

A Markdown file in your repo that Codex reads before every task. The onboarding note for a teammate who starts fresh each time.

Thursday: where the note goes



Committed in Git: the whole team shares it.



Thursday: rewrite Sam's notes for Codex

Told to Sam 👩‍💻	Written for Codex 🤖
"Handle errors properly"	**Raise AppError with an UPPER_SNAKE code**
"Remember to test"	**Run: python -m unittest discover -s tests -v**
"Keep docs updated"	**One CHANGELOG.md line under Unreleased**

The test for every rule: could a reviewer check it in the diff?

Thursday: the team's AGENTS.md

```
# Bookshop team rules

- Money is Decimal, never float.
- Invalid input: raise AppError with an UPPER_SNAKE code.   ← round 1
- Public functions: docstring with an Example: line.
- Before finishing, run: python -m unittest discover -s tests -v   ← round 2
- Add one line to CHANGELOG.md under ## Unreleased.   ← round 3
- Do not add dependencies.
```

Every review comment became a rule. Plain Markdown, about ten lines.

Demo



Friday: rerun Tuesday’s task

1. **NO NOTE**
   Ask Codex to add apply_coupon
2. **CHECK THE DIFF**
   Do the same 3 comments come back?
3. **ADD AGENTS.md**
   Copy the note to the repo root
4. **SAME PROMPT**
   New thread, identical words
5. **COMPARE**
   Did Codex follow the rules?

Friday: one review, zero ping-pong

🤖 **PR #58: add apply_coupon()**

- ✓ **raise AppError("INVALID_COUPON")**
- ✓ **Docstring with an Example: line**
- ✓ **Tests run with the team command**
- ✓ **CHANGELOG.md updated**

✅ **Approved.**
No comments needed.

Same prompt as Tuesday.
One Markdown file changed.

Your turn

What's in your team's onboarding notes
that Codex has never read?



Summary



Codex starts every task like a new hire

AGENTS.md is its onboarding note

Write rules a reviewer can check

Rules guide Codex. Review still checks